

Highly Complex Sentence Architecture

C2 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

C2 academic and literary writing often uses long sentences that nest several subordinate clauses, front entire clauses for emphasis, and pack dense noun phrases — all while remaining grammatically clear.

- a) Nested subordinate clauses — a main clause can contain a relative clause, which itself contains another clause, building layers of information.

The report, which the committee — most of whom had opposed the original plan — reluctantly approved, outlined a strategy that few believed would work.

- b) Multi-clause fronting — moving an entire subordinate clause (or more than one) to the front of the sentence for emphasis, cohesion with the previous sentence, or rhythm.

Although the data seemed conclusive, and although several experts had endorsed the findings, the board remained unconvinced.

What had once seemed an impossible goal, given the constraints they faced, now looked entirely achievable.

- c) High-density noun phrases and academic phrasing — combining nominalization, multiple modifiers and embedded clauses into a single compact subject or object.

The steady erosion of public trust in institutions once considered unimpeachable has reshaped modern political discourse.

Key architectural principles at C2:

- - Use dashes or parentheses to insert a clause without breaking the main sentence's flow.
- - Keep the main verb clearly identifiable even in a long sentence — readers should never lose track of the core subject-verb relationship.
- - Balance clause length: extremely long sentences need at least one shorter sentence nearby to maintain readability.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. The proposal, which had been debated for months and which several board members privately opposed, was finally approved.
- 2. Although the results were promising, and although the funding had already been secured, the project was ultimately shelved.
- 3. What had once been dismissed as a fringe theory is now widely accepted within the scientific community.
- 4. The gradual decline in voter turnout, a trend observed across most

Western democracies, has troubled political scientists for decades.

- 5. Having reviewed the evidence — evidence that, incidentally, contradicted the official account — the judge dismissed the case.
- 6. That she succeeded despite every obstacle placed in her path is a testament to her resilience.
- 7. The very policies designed to protect small businesses have, ironically, made survival harder for many of them.
- 8. Whatever conclusions one draws from the data, and however one interprets the underlying trends, the overall pattern remains undeniable.
- 9. It was not until the final report was published, months after the initial allegations surfaced, that the full scale of the scandal became clear.
- 10. The committee's decision, reached only after weeks of heated debate, satisfied almost no one.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: The report, which the committee approved it, outlined a new strategy.

Correct: The report, which the committee approved, outlined a new strategy.

Why: Don't repeat the object with a redundant pronoun ("it") once a relative pronoun ("which") already fills that role.

- 2. Incorrect: Although the data seemed conclusive, but the board remained unconvinced.

Correct: Although the data seemed conclusive, the board remained unconvinced.

Why: "Although" and "but" cannot both introduce the contrast — choose one.

- 3. Incorrect: What had once seemed impossible, now looked achievable it.

Correct: What had once seemed impossible now looked achievable.

Why: No comma is needed between a fronted "what" clause functioning as the subject and the main verb; and don't add a redundant "it" at the end.

- 4. Incorrect: The decline in trust, that scholars have studied extensively, reshaped politics.

Correct: The decline in trust, which scholars have studied extensively, reshaped politics.

Why: In a non-defining (comma-separated) relative clause, use "which," not "that."

- 5. Incorrect: Having reviewed the evidence, the case were dismissed by the judge.

Correct: Having reviewed the evidence, the judge dismissed the case.

Why: The subject right after a participle clause ("Having reviewed...") must be the one performing that action — here, the judge, not the case.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (choose which, that, or leave blank as appropriate for defining/non-defining clauses)
 - 1. The theory, ____ was first proposed decades ago, has recently gained new support.
 - 2. The report ____ she submitted last week contained several errors. (defining, no comma)
 - 3. Her argument, ____ few could refute, changed the course of the debate.
 - 4. The findings ____ the team published were later called into question.
 - 5. The policy, ____ had been in place for over a decade, was finally repealed.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (combine the short sentences into one complex sentence using the technique indicated)
 - 1. The plan was risky. Everyone knew this. The board approved it anyway. (use a fronted concessive clause)
 - 2. Trust in institutions has declined. This is a trend across many countries. It worries sociologists. (embed the second sentence as a non-defining relative clause / appositive)
 - 3. The scientists reviewed the data. The data had been collected over ten years. They reached a surprising conclusion. (use a participle clause + embedded relative clause)
 - 4. Nobody expected the merger to succeed. It succeeded anyway. This surprised the entire industry. (use a "that" nominal clause as the subject: "That...")
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. The proposal, that had taken months to draft, was rejected in minutes.
 - 2. Although the evidence was strong, but the jury hesitated.
 - 3. Having finished the analysis, the results were presented by the team.
 - 4. The decline, that experts had predicted for years, finally arrived.
 - 5. What seemed impossible at first, it became routine within months.
 - 6. The scandal, which it destroyed his career, was never fully explained.
- D. Guided Production
 - 1. Write one long sentence with a nested non-defining relative clause about a topic you know well (e.g., work, a hobby, current events).
 - 2. Write one sentence that fronts a full concessive clause ("Although...") before the main clause.
 - 3. Write one sentence with a "That..." clause functioning as the subject.
 - 4. Write one sentence using a participle clause ("Having + past participle...") followed correctly by its logical subject.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
 - 1. which
 - 2. (no relative pronoun needed; "that" also acceptable: that she submitted last week)
 - 3. which
 - 4. (no relative pronoun needed / that)
 - 5. which
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
 - 1. Although the plan was risky, and everyone knew this, the board approved it anyway.

- 2. Trust in institutions has declined, a trend observed across many countries, worrying sociologists. (or: ...a trend across many countries that worries sociologists.)
- 3. Having reviewed data collected over ten years, the scientists reached a surprising conclusion.
- 4. That nobody expected the merger to succeed, and yet it did, surprised the entire industry. (or: That the merger succeeded despite nobody expecting it surprised the entire industry.)
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. The proposal, which had taken months to draft, was rejected in minutes.
 - 2. Although the evidence was strong, the jury hesitated.
 - 3. Having finished the analysis, the team presented the results.
 - 4. The decline, which experts had predicted for years, finally arrived.
 - 5. What seemed impossible at first became routine within months.
 - 6. The scandal, which destroyed his career, was never fully explained.
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
 - 1. My grandmother's recipe book, which she compiled over fifty years and which none of us dared to modify, remains the closest thing our family has to a sacred text.
 - 2. Although the team had prepared for every possible scenario, the actual crisis unfolded in a way nobody had anticipated.
 - 3. That she managed to finish the project alone, without any support from management, says a great deal about her determination.
 - 4. Having spent the entire weekend rehearsing, the cast felt ready for opening night.